Omaha Platform

People's Party (Populist) National Convention · Omaha, NE · July 4, 1892

Source: People's Party Platform and Expression of Sentiments, Omaha (July 4, 1892), text via Teaching American History. Public domain.

Drafted at the founding convention of the People's Party in 1892, the Omaha Platform was the most ambitious reform program of the 19th century. It blamed farmers' and workers' suffering on collusion between corporations and corrupt government, and demanded a flexible currency, government ownership of railroads and telegraphs, direct election of senators, an income tax, and the secret ballot. Most of its planks looked radical in 1892 but became law during the Progressive Era and New Deal.

> *Connect: The Populists' anti-monopoly rhetoric echoes Jackson's Bank War message (Class 11). Both movements attacked concentrated economic power. How are they similar? Different?*

Key Passages

Preamble (Ignatius Donnelly)

> we meet in the midst of a nation brought to the verge of moral, political, and material ruin. Corruption dominates the ballot box, the legislatures, the Congress, and touches even the ermine of the bench. … The fruits of the toil of millions are boldly stolen to build up colossal fortunes for a few, unprecedented in the history of mankind … From the same prolific womb of governmental injustice, we breed the two great classes—tramps and millionaires.

Finance plank

> We demand free and unlimited coinage of silver and gold at the present legal ratio of 16 to 1. We demand that the amount of circulating medium be speedily increased to not less than $50 per capita. We demand a graduated income tax.

Transportation plank

> Transportation being a means of exchange and a public necessity, the government should own and operate the railroads in the interest of the people.

Expression of Sentiments — political reforms

> RESOLVED, That we demand a free ballot and a fair count in all elections and pledge ourselves to secure it to every legal voter without federal intervention, through the adoption by the states of the unperverted Australian or secret ballot system. … RESOLVED, That we commend to the favorable consideration of the people and the reform press the legislative system known as the initiative and referendum. RESOLVED, That we favor a constitutional provision limiting the office of president and vice president to one term, and providing for the election of senators of the United States by a direct vote of the people.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Agricultural depression, falling crop prices, debt, railroad monopolies, and the money supply; the Farmers' Alliances formed the People's Party.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Farmers, laborers, and voters in the South and West ahead of the 1892 election, along with the two major parties.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Populist leaders and farmers who saw corporations and banks as their oppressors; they looked for help from the federal government.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. HIPP — Purpose (multi-doc): Using this platform and ONE other reform-era document, argue what reformers in the 1890s thought was wrong with the U.S.
2. Which planks of the Omaha Platform eventually became federal law? In which decades?
3. Why did the Populist Party itself collapse so quickly after 1896?

The Omaha Platform

People's (Populist) Party · July 4, 1892

Source: People's Party Platform and Expression of Sentiments, Omaha (July 4, 1892), text via Teaching American History. Public domain. Non-contiguous passages are separated by [. . .]; shorter cuts inside a passage are marked with an ellipsis (. . .).

> The founding platform of the Populist Party gave voice to angry farmers and workers, demanding free silver, a graduated income tax, government ownership of railroads, and direct election of senators — ideas later absorbed into Progressive reform.

Preamble (Ignatius Donnelly)

The conditions which surround us best justify our cooperation; we meet in the midst of a nation brought to the verge of moral, political, and material ruin. Corruption dominates the ballot box, the legislatures, the Congress, and touches even the ermine of the bench. The people are demoralized; most of the states have been compelled to isolate the voters at the polling places to prevent universal intimidation and bribery. The newspapers are largely subsidized or muzzled, public opinion silenced, business prostrated, homes covered with mortgages, labor impoverished, and the land concentrating in the hands of capitalists. The urban workmen are denied the right to organize for self-protection; imported pauperized labor beats down their wages, a hireling standing army, unrecognized by our laws, is established to shoot them down, and they are rapidly degenerating into European conditions. The fruits of the toil of millions are boldly stolen to build up colossal fortunes for a few, unprecedented in the history of mankind; and the possessors of those, in turn, despise the Republic and endanger liberty. From the same prolific womb of governmental injustice, we breed the two great classes—tramps and millionaires.

[. . .]

We have witnessed for more than a quarter of a century the struggles of the two great political parties for power and plunder, while grievous wrongs have been inflicted upon the suffering people. We charge that the controlling influences dominating both these parties have permitted the existing dreadful conditions to develop without serious effort to prevent or restrain them. Neither do they now promise us any substantial reform. They have agreed together to ignore, in the coming campaign, every issue but one. They propose to drown the outcries of a plundered people with the uproar of a sham battle over the tariff, so that capitalists, corporations, national banks, rings, trusts, watered stock, the demonetization of silver, and the oppressions of the usurers may all be lost sight of. . . . we seek to restore the government of the Republic to the hands of "the plain people," with which class it originated.

[. . .]

We believe that the power of government—in other words, of the people—should be expanded (as in the case of the postal service) as rapidly and as far as the good sense of an intelligent people and the teachings of experience shall justify, to the end that oppression, injustice, and poverty shall eventually cease in the land.

[. . .]

Platform

Second—Wealth belongs to him who creates it, and every dollar taken from industry without an equivalent is robbery. "If any will not work, neither shall he eat." The interests of rural and civic labor are the same; their enemies are identical.

[. . .]

Finance

Finance—We demand a national currency, safe, sound, and flexible, issued by the general government only, a full legal tender for all debts, public and private, and that without the use of banking corporations, a just, equitable, and efficient means of distribution direct to the people, at a tax not to exceed 2 percent per annum, to be provided as set forth in the sub-

treasury plan of the Farmers' Alliance, or a better system; also by payments in discharge of its obligations for public improvements. We demand free and unlimited coinage of silver and gold at the present legal ratio of 16 to 1. We demand that the amount of circulating medium be speedily increased to not less than $50 per capita. We demand a graduated income tax.

[. . .]

Transportation

Transportation—Transportation being a means of exchange and a public necessity, the government should own and operate the railroads in the interest of the people. The telegraph, telephone, like the post-office system, being a necessity for the transmission of news, should be owned and operated by the government in the interest of the people.

Land

Land—The land, including all the natural sources of wealth, is the heritage of the people, and should not be monopolized for speculative purposes, and alien ownership of land should be prohibited. All land now held by railroads and other corporations in excess of their actual needs, and all lands now owned by aliens should be reclaimed by the government and held for actual settlers only.

[. . .]

Expression of Sentiments (political reforms)

RESOLVED, That we demand a free ballot and a fair count in all elections and pledge ourselves to secure it to every legal voter without federal intervention, through the adoption by the states of the unperverted Australian or secret ballot system. RESOLVED, That the revenue derived from a graduated income tax should be applied to the reduction of the burden of taxation now levied upon the domestic industries of this country. . . . RESOLVED, That we commend to the favorable consideration of the people and the reform press the legislative system known as the initiative and referendum. RESOLVED, That we favor a constitutional provision limiting the office of president and vice president to one term, and providing for the election of senators of the United States by a direct vote of the people.

Words to know

ermine of the bench — the judges; ermine fur symbolizes judicial robes and their supposed purity

hireling standing army — hired private guards (like Pinkertons) used to put down strikes

demonetization of silver — the 1873 decision to stop coining silver as money, shrinking the money supply

usurers — lenders who charge crushing interest

legal tender — money the law requires everyone to accept for debts

16 to 1 — minting silver freely at a fixed ratio of 16 ounces of silver to 1 of gold

Australian or secret ballot — a government-printed ballot marked in private, to stop vote buying and intimidation